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Charitable Giving: Towards a Model of Donor Behaviour

The need for the development of a comprehensive model of giving behaviour has never been greater. In the UK, the proportion of households electing to support charity is continuing a twenty year decline. This factor, combined with the accompanying and sharp increase in the number of registered charities has contributed to the creation of an ever more hostile fundraising environment. If they are to survive, charities seeking funds from individual donors will have to refine both the quality and targeting of their fundraising campaigns. It is the purpose of this article to develop a comprehensive model of giving behaviour to assist them in this process. The article draws on literature from the fields of marketing, economics, clinical psychology, social psychology, anthropology and sociology. The implications of the resultant model for fundraising strategy are discussed and opportunities for further research delineated.

Introduction

The number of nonprofit organisations has grown enormously over the past 20 years. Not only have their numbers increased but the scope of their work has widened also, to the point where they are involved with almost every aspect of human endeavour (CAF 1998). In the UK the nonprofit sector is valued at between £12 billion (Office of National Statistics, 1996) and £18 billion (Charity Commission, 1997) and in 1997 there were over 187,000 registered charities on the Charity Commission register in England and Wales (CAF, 1998). When one adds to this the 23,000 Scottish charities (Scottish Council for Voluntary Organisations, 1996) and the 5,000 in based in Northern Ireland (United Kingdom Voluntary Sector Almanac, 1996), the sheer scale of the sector becomes readily apparent.

This rise in the number and significance of nonprofits has not been without its problems however. In many countries levels of individual giving have failed to keep pace with both the increase in the number of voluntary organisations and the levels of need which these organisations exist to provide for. In the UK, for example, the number of registered charities continues to increase by

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approximately 10,000 per annum, a fact now causing some concern within the sector as levels of support, particularly from individual donors are failing to keep pace with this growth (CAF, 1998). It is also somewhat worrying to note that a much smaller percentage of UK households are currently supporting charities than would have been the case even ten years ago (Pharoah and Tanner, 1997). As the donor pool contracts and charities face increasing levels of competition, organisations will have to work ever harder to solicit the desired levels of support. An understanding of how the decision to donate is made, and an identification of the key variables that might have the propensity to influence that decision, is therefore now of particular significance and interest.

In the UK, the need for the development of a model of individual giving behaviour has never been greater. Recent work by the Institute for Fiscal Studies clearly shows that charitable giving is continuing its 20 year decline, leaving charities with the prospect of a considerable intensification in the level of competition for funds. Indeed, perhaps the most worrying aspect of this trend is the sharp decline in giving amongst households in their twenties and thirties, suggesting that charities will become increasingly reliant on an ageing segment of donors (Pharoah and Tanner, 1998). Charities clearly need to understand far more about the factors that can impact on giving behaviour and to tailor their approach to ensure that as wide as possible a segment of UK society can be persuaded to give. It is the purpose of this article to address this need for information by providing a detailed review of the available research. Thereafter the article will conclude by establishing an agenda for future research.

Modelling Giving Behaviour

The issue of how and why individuals elect to offer their help to others has puzzled philosophers and economists since the dawn of antiquity (Wispe, 1978). Over the past three centuries several schools of thought have begun to emerge from the economic, clinical psychology, social psychology, anthropology and sociology literatures. It is only comparatively recently, however, that marketing's contribution to the subject has been recognised and a succession of authors have now demonstrated its utility. (See for example Buzzell, 1970, Fox and Kotler, 1980, Lovelock and Weinberg, 1984, Kotler and Andreasen, 1987, Fraser et al 1988, Varadarajan and Menon, 1988 and Guy and Patton, 1989).

Aside from this plethora of studies, addressing specific aspects of charity giving, a few studies have also made attempts to synthesise the available literature and to develop a rather broader perspective on how and why individuals elect to give. Notable amongst these is the work by Guy and Patton (1989) and Burnett and Wood (1988). Whilst these studies are now somewhat dated, they represent the first real attempts to develop composite models of giving behavior. The study by Burnett and Wood (1988), in particular, was perhaps the most highly developed as it drew on a somewhat broader body of literature than was considered by Guy and Patton (1989). It should be noted, however, that neither study emphasised what might be regarded as the 'processing determinants' (see below) impacting on how the decision to select

between charitable alternatives might be derived. Since, as Milne and Gordon (1993) note, donors are becoming ever more discriminating, perhaps as a reaction to the increasingly diverse sets of stimuli to which they are exposed (Schmittlein and Peterson, 1994), it would now seem appropriate to include this additional set of variables within any proposed model. It should also be noted that since the early 1990s there has been an increasing recognition within nonprofit marketing circles of the diverse range of outputs that can emerge from fundraising activity. Previous studies have tended to regard the decision to donate (or not to donate) as the primary output from any model of giving behaviour. Fundraisers are now increasingly interested in outputs such as the level of the gift, the likely lifetime value of the donor and the extent to which he/she may be persuaded to support the organisation in ways other than with simple cash donations.

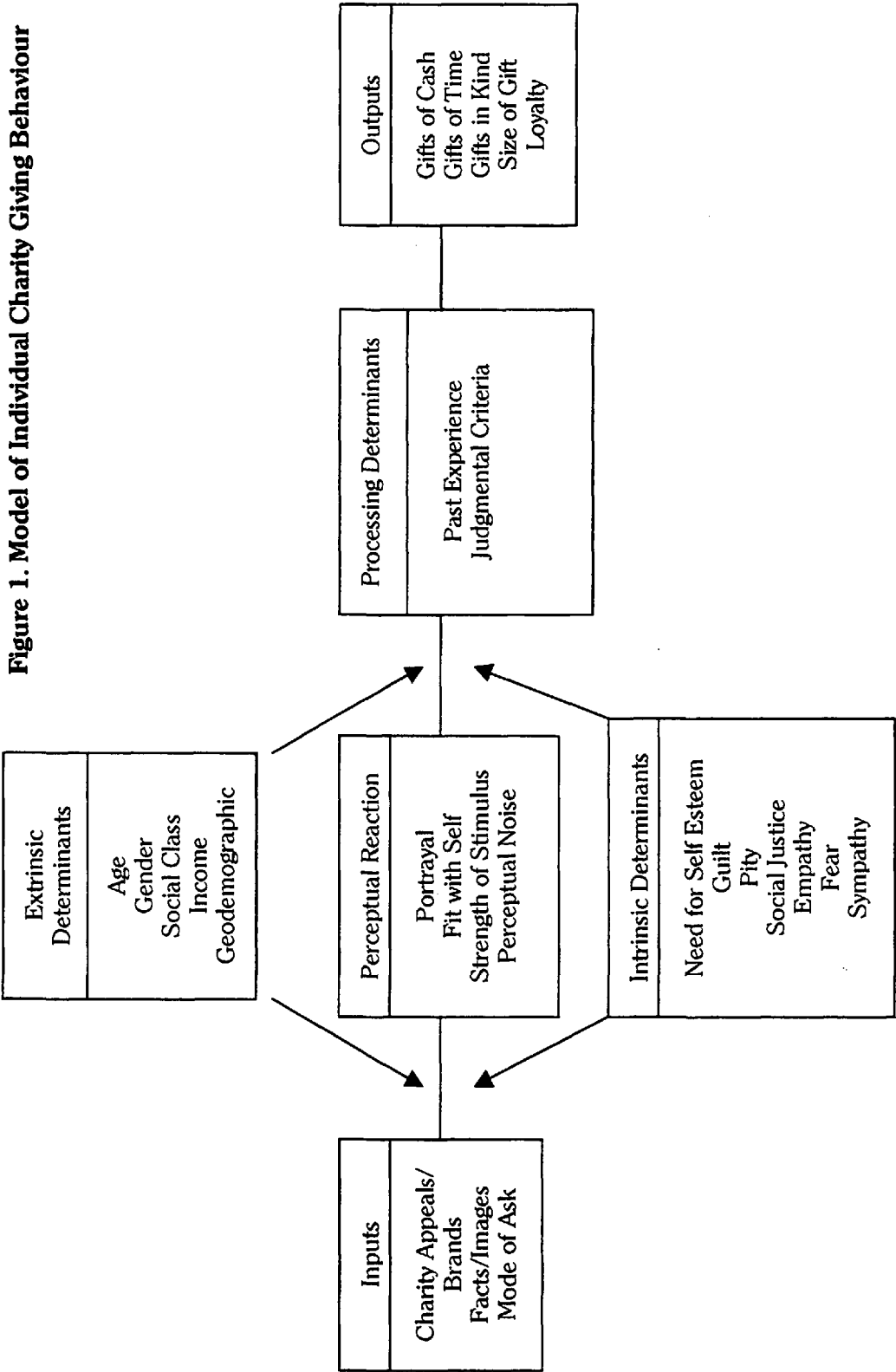
It is the purpose of this article to address many of the shortcomings of previous work in this area and to draw together each of the disparate strands of literature alluded to above. A theoretical model of giving behaviour (which will address a variety of outputs) will be developed, that could subsequently be tested through empirical research. The model postulated is illustrated in Figure 1.

Inputs

As the model clearly indicates there are a number of external inputs to the decision making process. Charities currently engage in a variety of different fundraising techniques employing media such as direct mail, telemarketing, face-to-face canvassing, door-to-door distribution, press advertising and, increasingly, radio advertising and DRTV (Direct Response Television) (Sargeant and Kaehler, 1998). The use of each of these media is potentially capable of generating a response from the prospects targeted. In the case of a number of the larger charities it has been argued that this process has been greatly facilitated by the presence of a well-known and 'trusted' brand. .

Roberts Wray (1994) was one of the first explicitly to debate the relevance of branding to the charity sector, with more recent work by Saxton (1995) suggesting that in the voluntary sector context a strong brand should both draw on, and project the beliefs and values of, its various stakeholders. Whilst these are perhaps rather less tangible than the facts about why an organisation exists and the nature of the beneficiary group, this latter class of variables can greatly aid a donor's understanding of the charity concerned and suggest very potent reasons why it might be worthy of support (Dixon, 1997). It is only comparatively recently, however, that there has been much formal interest in branding within the sector, but whilst as Tapp (1996, p335) notes, "charities do not describe much of what they do as 'branding', organisations have long been concerned with maintaining a consistent style and tone of voice and conducting periodic reviews of both policies and actions to ensure that a consistent personality is projected." In the author's view, the clarity with which this 'personality' is projected will have a direct impact on an organisation's ability to fundraise. (See also Grounds and Harkness, 1998).

Figure 1. Model of Individual Charity Giving Behaviour



The variable 'mode of ask' is also important, because charities can clearly elect to approach donors in a variety of different ways. Reference has already been made to the variety of media that can be used for the purposes of solicitation and the literature suggests that the profile of the donors recruited by each of these means will vary in terms of their demographic, lifestyle and behavioural characteristics. Donors recruited by direct mail, for example, tend on average to support an organisation for the longest period of time, whilst DRTV donors tend to give somewhat higher sums on average than any other category of donor. (See for example Sargeant and McKenzie, 1998).

It also seems clear that the approach adopted within each respective media will impact on the pattern of support exhibited. Weyant and Smith (1987), for example, found that lowering the sums requested in direct mail greatly increased the donor compliance rate. Other writers have concentrated on the manner in which the ask is framed. Authors such as Fraser et al (1988), Reeves et al (1987), Reingen (1978) and Weyant (1984) identified that legitimising paltry contributions (i.e. with a phrase such as 'every penny will help') can greatly improve compliance in face-to-face forms of solicitation. Brockner et al (1984), Reeves et al (1987) and Weyant and Smith (1987) meanwhile, conclude that this approach is less effective in other less personal forms of fundraising.

The utilisation of techniques which engender a stronger sense of relationship have also been found to increase compliance (Rolloff, 1987; Rolloff et al, 1988; Aune and Basil, 1994), with a number of writers now noting the 'foot in the mouth' effect. In essence there is now strong evidence to suggest that on commencing a solicitation, asking people how they feel, then acknowledging their response and then asking for a donation greatly enhances compliance. Howard (1990) argues that people will behave in a manner consistent with the state they have described themselves as feeling. If prospects reply that they 'feel great' they will strive to maintain a consistency in what Osgood and Tannenbaum (1955) refer to as their 'general affective state'. It is therefore much less likely that a donation will be refused (See also Bem, 1965; Howard, 1990 and Cialdini and Schroeder, 1976). It is interesting to note that the gender of the asker would also appear to have an impact (Lindskold et al, 1977), as would both the level of familiarity the prospect has with the individual making the request (Macaulay, 1975) and hindering the prospect's escape, perhaps through the strategic selection of the location at which the ask will be made, e.g. standing at the entrance/exit to a building (Staub and Baer, 1974).

There is also evidence that preceding a target request with an initial request (i.e. multiple asks) will increase prospect compliance. Multiple requests are effective both when the initial request is lower than the target (Cann et al, 1975; Freedman and Fraser, 1966), or larger (Cann et al, 1975; Cialdini and Ascani, 1976; Mowen and Cialdini, 1980).

The provision of 'models' (e.g. a celebrity seen to be offering support) can also influence contributory behaviour by leading to the creation of social norms thereby legitimising and encouraging the giving behaviour (Krebs, 1970). It does seem likely, however, that the use of models would be most appropriate in

impersonal forms of fundraising, since the reasons for giving are likely to be altruistic and not merely a response to what Jackson and Latane (1981) refer to as a mild form of 'social mugging'.

Perceptual Reaction

Whatever form the ask might eventually take, there are a variety of variables which the literature suggests will tend to impact on a potential donor's perceptual reaction to the message being conveyed. In particular donors receiving positively framed messages, designed to make them feel good, are statistically more likely to respond than those donors offered primarily negative messages, designed to make them feel bad (Benson and Catt, 1978). The key variables impacting on perceptual reaction would appear, however, to be the portrayal of the individual(s) in need, the fit of the charity with a given donor's self image, the strength of the stimulus and the degree to which perceptual noise is present. Each of these variables will now be considered in turn.

The manner in which recipients of the charitable 'product' are portrayed can have an impact on recall, attitudes towards support and actual giving behaviour. Donors will tend to support those charities that represent the needy in an acceptable way (Eayrs and Ellis, 1990). Pictures, for example, of an overtly handicapped child, have been shown to actually decrease the response to door-to-door giving solicitations. It is also interesting to note that female subjects would appear to engender greater rates of compliance than male subjects (Feinman, 1978; Gruder and Cook, 1971; Milgram, 1970).

Appeals for charities concerned with disability often emphasise the dependability of those individuals with the respective disability. There is now considerable evidence that such appeals are very successful in engendering feelings of sympathy (Brolley and Anderson, 1986; Feldman and Feldman, 1985; Lattin, 1977; Jones, 1985; Roehler 1961) and feelings of guilt and pity (Feldman and Feldman, 1985; Krebs and Whitten, 1972 and Pieper, 1975). The literature is less united however, in respect of the degree to which dependency should be exhibited. Writers such as Berkowitz and Daniels (1962) and Midlarsky (1971) conclude that greater degrees of perceived dependency are related to greater degrees of help. Wagner and Wheeler (1969) meanwhile conclude that when the level of dependency is perceived as permanent, the level of dependency has no effect on the amount likely to be given. Using different terminology Adler et al (1991) identify that portraying recipients as succumbing to their condition, (by contrast to coping) has no impact on the pattern of donations. They do however identify a strong impact on the subsequent attitudes of the donor towards the recipient group.

This latter point is of particular interest since many authors argue that portraying people with disabilities as dependent may well harm the long term interests of the beneficiary group by reinforcing negative stereotypes and attitudes (Elliot and Byrd, 1982; Harris and Harris, 1977). Positive portrayals on the other hand seem to engender positive attitudes (Harris, 1975; Shurka et al,

1982). On a related theme, there is in addition evidence that attractive people are perceived as more worthy than unattractive people (Latane and Nida, 1981). The portrayal of the responsibility of recipients for their own condition can also impact on compliance. Piliavin et al (1975) identified that the extent to which an individual could be blamed for his/her needy condition would directly impact on both the degree of compliance and the levels of support proffered.

In respect of the second variable 'fit with desired self image' Coliazzzi et al (1984) noted that individuals are more likely to help those that are perceived as being similar to themselves. They will thus tend to filter those messages from charities existing to support disparate segments of society. Of course, charities exist to support work, not only with other members of human society but also wider environmental or ecological concerns from which every segment of society can ultimately stand to benefit. Dichter (1972) offers some explanation for support of this category of cause, suggesting that giving can greatly aid one's self image or self worth. Indeed generous giving to all manner of different causes has long been a source of prestige for individuals in the U.S. (Schwartz, 1967). Donors may thus prefer to concentrate on those categories of cause which are either perceived as most relevant to their segment of society, or which are perceived more widely as supporting how they wish to see themselves, or have others see them. As Schwartz (1967) notes, donating can confer an identity on both the recipient and the donor. Work by Yavas et al (1980) suggests that possessing a generous, loving, self image is more important for donors than non-donors. Donors should therefore be portrayed in ads as generous and loving to help them project the self-image that they would wish others to accept (Douglas et al, 1967)

A variety of authors have chosen to focus on the strength of the stimulus generated by a particular charity. Clearly the stronger the stimulus, the easier it will be for charities to cut through what Schmittlein and Peterson (1996) refer to as the 'deluge' of current charitable appeals. There is evidence that the strength of the stimulus is related to a number of variables. The first is the perceived urgency of the recipient situation. In general, high degrees of urgency would appear to engender high degrees of support (See for example Chierco et al, 1982; Farrington and Kidd, 1977; Newman, 1977; Pancer et al, 1979; Schwartz, 1974). It would also appear that approaches which build up the degree of personal responsibility will be more effective at engendering a response (See for example Geer and Jermecky, 1973). Other key variables warranting consideration under this general heading include the degree of personalisation attained (Weldon, 1984) and the clarity of the request. Clear and unambiguous requests for support are more likely to engender compliance than those that are vague or general in nature (Clark and Word, 1972)

The final variable in this section of the model relates to the extent to which 'perceptual noise' might be present. With over 220,000 registered charities now in existence in the UK and the number increasing at the rate of approximately 10% per annum, the propensity for donors to become confused by the diversity of appeals has now been greatly enhanced (CAF, 1993). We may therefore

conclude that the degree of compliance in the case of an individual charity will depend on the extent to which other, perhaps similar, organisations are currently marketing themselves to potential supporters.

Processing Determinants

Two key categories of variable will impact on the manner in which the giving decision is processed, namely the donor's past experience with a given charity (and with charitable giving in general), and the criteria that he/she might use to evaluate potential organisations for support. Each of these dimensions will now be considered in turn.

Milne and Gordon (1993) recognise that donors are becoming more sophisticated, discriminating and selective, preferring to develop deeper relationships with those organisations they choose to support. Thus, once recruited to support a charity, a given donor will be significantly more likely to give again in the future (Kaehler and Sargeant, 1998). Indeed, donors are reported as increasingly seeking relationships from the charities that they do elect to support and are, in the US in particular, expecting fundraisers "to create high tech intimacy via database marketing" (Nichols, 1995, p18). There is also evidence that once charitable giving is stimulated, an individual will be significantly more likely to give to other causes in the future. Once giving regularly it would appear that the norms attaching to the role are strengthened and made personal (Callero et al, 1987).

Perhaps one of the prolific sections of the charitable literature relates to those issues which are most likely to form part of a given donor's judgmental criteria for determining whether or not a particular charity is worthy of support. Indeed a number of such criteria are suggested. Writers such as Collard (1978) have tended to see the process of giving as being determined largely by selfish economic considerations. Wagner (1991) notes that economists have only recently moved away from the classical theory of exchange which assumed that uncoerced exchange would not take place unless some form of benefit accrued to both parties to the transaction. It has only recently been assumed that utility could take emotional as well as material form (Arrow, 1972). Thus, those who subscribe to this school of thought believe that the desire to give is borne out of a wish to achieve some form of individual return. Donors will therefore select charities to support on the basis of whether they have benefited in the past or believe that they will in the future (Krebs, 1970; Frisch and Gerrard, 1981, or Amos, 1982). Individuals could, for example, give to those organisations that will do them political good and/or serve to enhance their career, perhaps through the networking opportunities that will be accorded (Amos, 1982; Frisch and Gerrard, 1981). Donors may also evaluate potential recipient organisations against the extent to which their support will be visible, or noticeable by others within their social group, thereby enhancing the donor's standing therein. (Stroebe and Frey, 1982)

This view of a rational economic donor has been much criticised because it

fails to explain a large number of charitable gifts, either where no benefit would appear to accrue to the donor, or where the gift itself is anonymous. Sugden (1982), in particular argues that individuals might also act on principles rather than simply self-interest. Bolnick (1975) argues that economic irrationality can be explained by placing man in his social context. Seemingly irrational behaviour can be explained by reference to other intrinsic or social rewards that can accrue from the act of giving. Even under these circumstances, however, the literature still suggests that a variety of judgmental criteria may apply. Notable among these is the issue of the perceived effectiveness/efficiency of the organisation attempting to solicit support. A number of well-publicised abuses of donated monies have served to sensitise donors to these issues. In the US, for example, the National Kids Day Foundation raised \$4 million between 1948 and 1963 and spent the entire amount on fundraising and administrative costs (Cutlip, 1980). When challenged, charity administrators said the foundation's purpose was to promote the idea of needy children rather than actually providing aid. Glaser (1994, p178) found that the variable "an adequate amount spent per program" was the most important factor in the decision to contribute to charitable organisations. Donors appear to have a clear idea of what represents an acceptable percentage of income that may be applied to both administration and fundraising costs. Warwick (1994) identified that donors expect that the ratio between administration/fundraising costs and so-called charitable expenditure would be 20:80. It is interesting to note that despite this expectation most donors believe that the actual ratio is closer to 50:50. Harvey and McCrohan (1988) found that 60% was a significant threshold, with charities spending at least 60% of their donations on charitable programs achieving significantly higher levels of donation. Steinberg (1986) suggests that this is something of an anomaly since fundraising costs in particular are sunk, and should therefore not enter into a donor's decision to support a given charity.

On a related theme, perceived mismanagement by charity administrators and trustees can also impact negatively on donations (Baily and Bruce, 1992), although it remains unclear how donors actually draw such conclusions. In recognition of this Ormstedt (1994, p140) identifies that "the public and the media need a better understanding of the realities of (charity costs)." (See also Greenlee and Gordon, 1997). Voluntary organisations continue to be seen as amateurish but effective (Nightingale, 1973)

Moderating Variables

As the model in Figure 1 clearly illustrates, the manner in which charity appeals are perceived and the decision making process conducted will both be impacted by a variety of both intrinsic and extrinsic variables. Each of these will now be considered in turn.

Extrinsic Determinants

The key category of external determinant variables is undoubtedly that of the

demographic profile of the charity donor/prospect. The age of an individual would appear to be directly related to his/her propensity to engage both in charity giving and the level at which such behaviour will take place (i.e. the sums donated). (Nichols, 1992; Midlarsky and Hannah, 1989)

According to Royer (1989), 60% of charitable gifts in the USA come from people aged 60-76. A similarly skewed profile of charitable support has been reported in the UK (IFS, 1998). Bar-Tel (1976), Peterson et al (1977), Rushton and Wheelwright (1980) and Peterson et al (1977) all identify that the charitable behaviour of children increases with age. It would also appear that adolescence is not necessarily the period of self-absorption that it is commonly perceived to be. Charitable behaviour was still exhibited by individuals in this age category (Bandura and Walters, 1959; Coles and Brenner, 1969; Offer, 1985)

In general however the younger generations in our society appear to be less motivated to give to charity than would have previously been the case (IFS 1998). As Simpson (1986) puts it "(in the UK) this generation seems less inclined to believe in philanthropy. They are much more consumption driven, they buy things for themselves. Young people today like to spend money on eating out, on clothes and other things – more than people did 20 years ago." Even in the US there has been an apparent resurgence of materialistic values among younger US consumers (Belk, 1985; Belk and Pollay, 1985 and Yankelovich, 1981)

Despite the apparently contracting pool of donors, however, not all authors are pessimistic about likely patterns of future giving. Some writers account for the skewed age distribution of givers by explaining that older people experience less social interaction than their younger counterparts. This results from a physiological decline (impacting on mobility), age related losses (including retirement and the death of a spouse – Atchlet, 1987; Lemon et al, 1972), and a less positive self image due to a reduced lack of control and self determination (Ward, 1977). Elderly members of society may thus be able to experience pseudo-social interaction through the relationships they build up with charities and in essence exchange one form of social interaction with another (Graney and Graney, 1974; Caplow, 1984). Given that the elderly of today are much more likely to be wealthy than their predecessors, this represents a considerable future opportunity for charities to address and not necessarily a threat (Moschis, 1992).

A variable related to the age of the prospect is that of 'lifestage'. The motivation for giving to a number of charities, notably those connected in some way with medical research may be related to a great extent to the level of involvement an individual might have with the problem addressed by a charity. Those individuals who either suffer from a particular complaint, or who are perhaps related to a sufferer will be somewhat more disposed to giving than those that have no such association (See for example Bruce (1998) or Nichols (1991)).

The variable 'gender' has also been shown to have a key impact on giving behaviour. As Braus (1994, p48) notes, "many of today's donors, particularly baby boomers and women want a precise explanation of how their money will be used. They also want the opportunity to choose how the money will be spent."

The author also identified that women tend to want more information about how the money is actually used, they prefer one-off donations as opposed to covenanted support and tend to give smaller amounts than men, although the gap is narrowing. In addition women appear to give more 'from the heart than the head.'

Not surprisingly the variable social class/income is also an important determinant of charitable behaviour. Whilst economic downturns constrain both the desire to give and the actual ability to do so (Galaradi, 1989) this effect would appear to constrain the lower income earners rather than those towards the top of the social scale. Writers such as Mears (1992) and Jones and Posnett (1991) see giving as income elastic, although it is important to note that not only the amounts given will vary as one moves up the social strata, but also the rational for support. Radley and Kennedy (1992) identified that the lower socio-economic groups tend to see the needy as a group to be pitied because of their treatment at the hand of fate. Promotional messages stressing the ability of even a small gift to alleviate pain and suffering are therefore likely to be most effective. The higher socio-economic groups by contrast, particularly those from the professions, give not only for the amelioration of suffering but also for the longer term change in their situation. Support is thus prompted by a need to make a change in a social structure and promotional messages could perhaps reflect this motivation. Authors such as Amato (1985) also conclude that professional people tend to become more involved in their charitable giving.

This theme of involvement would also seem to be of importance to particularly high net worth individuals. Boris (1987, p239) in a study involving interviews with 100 wealthy philanthropists identified that "virtually every major philosophical current is reflected in the motives of donors", including feelings of civic responsibility, egoism, progressivism and scientific problem solving. In a similar study Schervish and Herman in 140 interviews with individuals whose net worth was in excess of \$1million dollars identified nine 'logics' of philanthropy each implying a high degree of involvement with the causes selected for support.

Interestingly the poor and extremely wealthy give a much higher proportion of their income than the middle class (Silver, 1980) and those living in small town/rural settings are more willing to exhibit helping behaviours than city dwellers (Latane and Nida, 1981)

The personality of a given individual does not in general appear to be a good indicator of charity support (Penrod, 1983). A number of studies have however highlighted that the self-confident are more likely to help than other categories of individual (Berkowitz, 1972). There is also evidence that intrinsically motivated people do more for charity than self-centred, external reward seekers (Reykowski, 1982).

It therefore seems clear that the individual characteristics of the prospect/donor will have a considerable impact on their giving behaviour. A number of studies have in addition suggested that the existence of social norms may also be an issue. Morgan et al, (1979) for example, identify that a significant percentage of philanthropic activity is motivated by normative concerns. People

appear to pay considerable attention to what others contribute. Judgements in respect of giving are therefore made in terms of beliefs about what is normative for the group (Blake et al, 1955; Macaulay, 1970; Clark and Word, 1972; Bryan and Test, 1967).

The latter concept of group is of particular significance since individuals perceive themselves as members of some groups, but not others (Hogg and Abrams, 1988). Since it was identified earlier that individuals would tend to support other individuals perceived as similar to themselves, the perception of group membership is key for fundraisers to understand and exploit in their solicitation activity. As Turner and Oakes (1986) notes, the self can be viewed as a series of abstract categories and thus "any attempt to understand the act of giving as an individual (behavioural) end point is likely to miss important features of what charity means in its fullest sense". (Radley and Kennedy, 1995, p705). Indeed pressure to conform to the norms of behaviour expected by various societal groups has been explored in a number of studies resulting in the derivation of group incentives where no individual incentive could previously be identified (Ireland and Johnson, 1970; Olson, 1971; Tullock, 1966; Keating et al, 1981)

Intrinsic Determinants

The penultimate class of variables to be defined within the model is that of the intrinsic determinants of charitable giving behaviour. This class of variable specifically addresses the underlying individual motives for electing to support a charity at a given level. They can assist donors in filtering out those charity appeals that are likely to be of most relevance and can help in structuring the evaluation process that will subsequently be conducted to ultimately define the pattern of support exhibited.

Key amongst these is the extent to which the donor feels empathy with the recipient. (See for example Mount and Quirion, 1988). Empathy may be defined as an individual's emotional arousal elicited by the expression of emotion in another (Aronfreed, 1968; Berger, 1962; Shelton and Rogers, 1981). Whilst intuitively sound the concept of empathy suffers from a lack of construct validity and a lack of clear measurement and manipulation techniques (Wispe, 1986). Having said this the most commonly employed operationalisation of empathy is that of 'cognitive perspective taking' (Eisenberg and Miller, 1987). Despite the difficulties of definition a number of studies have explicitly addressed the impact of empathy on giving behaviour and found a strong association between the level of empathy attained and the likelihood of providing help (e.g. Coke et al, 1978; Eisenberg and Miller, 1987). To be effective however manipulations must be powerful enough to arouse empathy, but not so powerful that they become personally distressing to the donor (Fultz et al, 1986).

The motive 'sympathy' has also received attention in the literature, largely being viewed as a value expressive function, aiding individuals to conform to personally held norms (Clary and Synder, 1991; Schwartz, 1977). Again, there would appear to be a relationship between the degree of sympathy engendered

and both the propensity to donate and the chosen level of support. (Batson, 1990; Fultz et al, 1986) A variety of other potential motives for giving have been identified including fear, guilt and pity which have been found to impact both on compliance and the extent thereof (Feldman and Feldman, 1985; Krebs and Whitten, 1972; Pieper, 1975).

Charity giving can of course be motivated by a givers self interest (see for example Pitts and Skelly, 1984; Sherry, 1983). Whilst we have already reviewed a number of these factors, the ability of a charitable donation to enhance feelings of self esteem has also been noted. Piliavin et al (1975), for example, identify that blood donations can often engender feelings of heroism on the part of the giver. Schwartz (1967) noted that donations might be a way of 'atoning for sins' thereby enhancing the self worth of the donor. Variables such as 'importance' self esteem and recognition have often been identified as key motivations for giving (see for example Haggberg, 1992; Kotler and Andreasen, 1987 and Dowd, 1975). In the case of the latter author, Dowd argued that individuals will only engage in an exchange of value where the outcomes are perceived to be at least equal to the inputs. In the opinion of the author inputs and outputs can be both material and psychosocial. (See also Walster et al, (1973)).

Miller (1977) argued from social justice motivation theory (Lerner, 1975) that if people witness undue suffering their belief in a just world will be threatened – consequently they will be motivated to respond to restore their faith in a just world. Miller also identified that helping behaviour would be increased when the need is not widespread and the duration of the need (persistence) is short. It is interesting to note that most charity communications appear based on the exact opposite of this position. Appeals tend to stress the ongoing nature of the need for support and make much of the number of individuals currently being impacted with the affliction/cause for concern.

It seems clear from the foregoing that a variety of different factors have the impact to effect charity giving behaviour. The factors are often complex and inter-related and suggest both altruistic and selfish motivations for giving. It is interesting to note that as early as 1981 writers such as Hoffman were already beginning to question whether altruistic motivations for support truly existed, despite an interesting debate around whether the existence of a so-called altruistic gene might enhance the genetic fitness and thus chances for survival of a species (Silver 1980). Margolis (1982) argued strongly in favour of the existence of purely altruistic motives for giving and the literature does, in general, now tend to concur with this view (Clary and Snyder, 1991; Piliavin and Charng, 1990).

Output

The final dimension of the model concerns the output from the decision making process. Charities tend in practice to be supported in a variety of different ways. Gifts may consist of monetary donations, gifts of time, or even gifts in kind, where perhaps goods are exchanged with the charity for onward transmission to donors, or to be used in some way in connection with the operations of the

organisation. There are, however, two other key outputs from the model, which must be considered. Donors can clearly elect to support their chosen charity at a variety of different levels. The share of a particular individual's charitable expenditure will become an increasingly important variable for charities to consider particularly in the UK where, as has been previously noted, the 'donor pool' has been shown to be contracting. (Pharoah and Tanner, 1997).

Allied to this latter output, the question of donor loyalty is also of significance. Uncommitted givers (i.e. individuals giving a series of single donations) tend to remain loyal to an organisation for a period of no more than five years, with a 50% attrition rate normally being experienced between the first and second donation. Committed givers (e.g. covenantors, or giftaiders) tend to remain loyal for somewhat longer, but even then the duration of the relationship would tend to extend no further than 6 to 7 years (Sargeant and McKenzie, 1998). As charities gain a more detailed understanding of the lifetime value of their donors, it seems likely that the success of fundraising activity may in the future be measured, not only by the immediate returns that are thereby generated, but also by changes in the longevity of donor relationships.

A greater understanding of the variables in the model postulated in this paper would assist charities in focussing their efforts on those individuals most likely to offer some form of support. Enhanced opportunities for donor targeting, based perhaps of the extrinsic determinants of giving behaviour highlighted in this paper, should serve to greatly reduce the costs of a given donor recruitment programme. Moreover as organisations begin to understand how information is processed by donors and the intrinsic determinants of behaviour, charities can more effectively tailor the messages contained in their promotional appeals to add relevance for their potential new donors and those who have given previously to the organisation.

More generally, in other forms of both personal and non-personal communications, charities would be advised to give consideration to the processing determinants that will be used in reaching an ultimate decision in respect of whether or not a particular donation will be made. A donor's past experience with a charity and their satisfaction with the standard of service received will clearly have a relevance here, as will the judgmental criteria that will be employed to select between the charitable options available to them. Charity branding, annual reports, media coverage and the overall profile of an organisation all have the capacity to enhance or detract from the evaluations that donors make against these criteria.

Directions For Future Research

In this paper we have postulated a model of donor giving behaviour, consolidating the marketing, economic, clinical psychology, social psychology, anthropology and sociology literatures. Further research will clearly be necessary to test the proposed model and to define the exact nature of the relationships between the variables identified. Whilst it seems clear that each of these could

potentially offer some utility to charity fundraisers, the extent to which each variable might vary in its significance and impact remains uncertain. Further empirical work is therefore essential.

The reader will appreciate that much of the previous research, and hence the model postulated in this paper, are based on the premise that charity donations are the output from a cognitive process involving considerable information processing. In the consumer behaviour literature authors such as Kassarian (1981) have questioned the extent to which this assumption may be regarded as legitimate. Indeed, Hibbert and Horne (1996) question this assumption specifically in the context of donor behaviour, claiming that giving may be more a response to social learning and conditioning than as a result of a cognitive process. Given the variety of forms that charity giving can take, from the 'social mugging' referred to by Jackson and Latane (1981), to planned giving activity such as giftaid, where an ongoing commitment may be required, it would seem appropriate to investigate the extent to which a cognitive model may be appropriate in the context of specific forms of giving. Intuitively one might expect that donations to a charity street collection may derive more from social conditioning, whereas a decision to become involved in the giftaid scheme is likely to be high involvement with an inherently high degree of cognitive processing. Further research to establish the extent to which a cognitive model of giving might be appropriate in specific giving contexts could therefore prove greatly instructive.

Additional research investigating the relationship of each of the variables in the model to specific categories of output is also warranted. Whilst considerable work has now been conducted on the relationship between many of the variables in the model and a propensity to donate, there is a general paucity of research relating to the determinants of the size of gift and the related issue of donor lifetime value. Moreover a key area of particular concern to fundraisers is the question of donor loyalty. Whilst studies have examined the determinants of loyalty in the for-profit arena there has been comparatively little interest to date in the form that these variables might take in a not-for-profit, fundraising context.

Indeed, the need for the development and refinement of a comprehensive model of charity giving behaviour has never been greater. The environmental pressures impacting on fundraising activity have already been noted, but charities have also faced much criticism in recent years from those who regard the sector's 'love affair' with marketing to have gone too far. In particular, Lee (1998), warns fundraisers that they risk becoming the 'used car salesmen' of the sector if they increasingly embrace 'techniques' and lose sight of the real reason for their existence. If marketing is to continue to enjoy its widespread acceptance within the sector, such critics must be silenced. Future marketing activity must be based on a sound understanding of how and why donors elect to give and the practice of fundraising must reflect this. Further empirical work would greatly assist fundraisers in enhancing the quality, precision and performance of their communications with donors and thereby ensure the future health and stability of the voluntary sector.

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